

BEST COLLEGES AWARDS 2023
Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan (7th from left) with India Today Chairman & Editor-in-Chief Aroon Purie (8th from left), Group editorial director Raj Chengappa (5th from left) and winners of the Best Colleges Awards at the India Today Education Conclave 2023

mon University Entrance Test (CUET) and the shift away from the 10+2 school education system, while also talking about legacy challenges such as inequality of access to education in urban and rural areas, high dropout rates, gender disparities, inadequate funding and the need for curriculum updates.

The conclave also saw the launch of INDIA TODAY's new education portal, the Best Colleges of India website, building on almost three decades of the India Today-MDRA Best Colleges survey—the most credible and exhaustive ranking of Indian institutions of higher learning. Following the launch, Pradhan announced the 2023 Best Colleges awards for institutes across 14 streams.

Other sessions delved into topics like the transformation of school education, capitalising on India's demographic dividend, and how to develop institutes that are global winners.

On the transformation of school education, Sanjay Kumar, secretary of the Union ministry of education's department of school education & literacy, explained how complex the current situation is. "We have 26.4 crore children going to 14.89 lakh schools, being taught by 97 lakh teachers...and their examination system is being governed by 60 school boards. These are the numbers we are [dealing with," he said. He also offered a financial view of the NEP to stress the distance yet to be covered: "The NEP says we should spend about 6 per cent of our GDP on education. The current figure is 4.64 per cent."

THE CONCLAVE SAW THE LAUNCH OF INDIA TODAY'S NEW OFFERING—THE BEST COLLEGES OF INDIA WEBSITE

One of the most interesting talks was delivered by Dr Dinesh Singh, chancellor of K.R. Mangalam University. Addressing a session titled 'How can India produce globally top-ranking universities?', Dr Singh stressed the need to learn from institutions at the very top. "Everybody talks about Harvard...but if you look at Harvard, for more than a hundred years, Harvard